Unit 8

Lead Sheets, Simplifying and Review

New: Chord symbols (C, Am7, G7/B, Fmaj7, Bdim, C/E); playing from a lead sheet; review

Much of the music a pianist is handed is not written out at all: a tune with chord symbols above it, a "lead sheet". Hymnals, folk-song books, musicals and jazz standards all use them. The pianist plays the tune (or lets a singer have it) and makes the accompaniment from the symbols.

This last unit teaches you to read chord symbols as fast as notes, and ends the course with a review: one exercise of each kind from this volume, and the opening of one of the best-loved piano pieces ever written.

What is new

Chord symbols

A letter names the chord's root: C is C major (C E G). A small m makes it minor (Am: A C E). 7 adds the minor seventh above the root (G7: G B D F); maj7 adds the major seventh (Cmaj7: C E G B); m7 is a minor chord with a minor seventh (Dm7: D F A C). 6 adds the sixth (C6: C E G A).

Slash chords

A letter after a slash is the bass note: G7/B is G7 with B in the bass; C/E is C major with E in the bass. Play the bass note with the left hand and the chord above it.

Realising a lead sheet

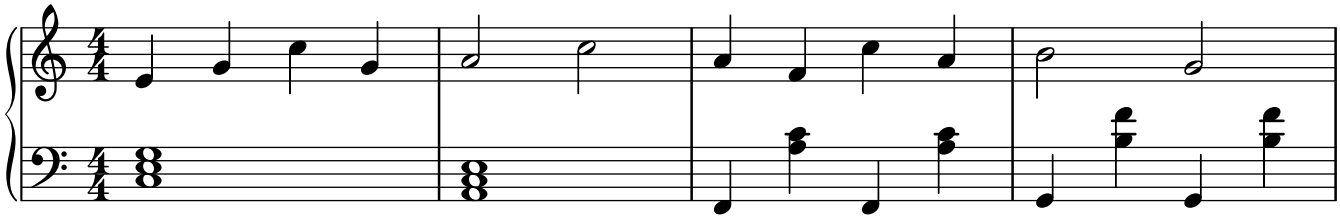
Start simple: the left hand plays the chord in root position, one per bar, while the right hand plays the tune. Then break the chord up: bass note and chord (oom-pah), or a broken chord (root, fifth, tenth). Keep the left hand below the tune.

Simplifying, again

If a passage is too hard at sight, keep the tune and the bass and drop the inner notes (Unit 5). Keep the beat going: a simple version in time is better than a full version that stops.

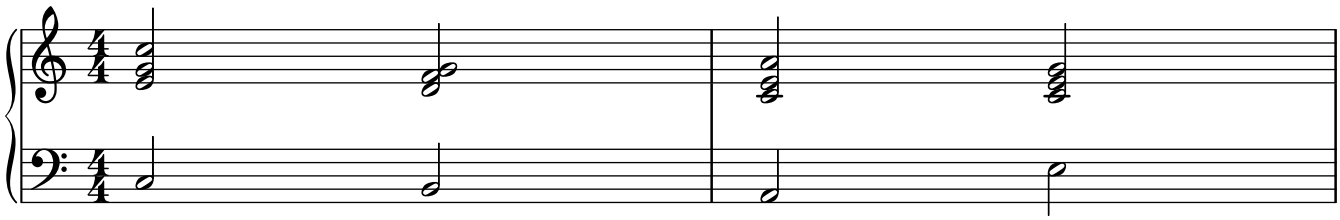
One lead sheet, three ways

The symbols C, Am, F and G7. Bars 1-2: the left hand plays each chord in root position; bars 3-4: bass note and chord (oom-pah).



Slash chords

C, G7/B (B in the bass), Am, C/E: the bass line falls and rises by step under the chords.



Reading tips

1. Before you play, read the chord symbols of the whole lead sheet aloud: "C, A minor, F, G seven".
2. Play the bass note of every symbol first (the root, or the note after the slash).
3. Find the chords near each other: Am after C keeps two notes, G7 after C keeps one.
4. Keep the left hand's accompaniment simple and steady; the tune is what the listener follows.
5. In the review, name the skill each exercise practises before you start.

Part A: Lead sheets: triads ♩ = 72

Lead sheets with major and minor chords. Play the tune with the right hand and each chord in root position with the left; then play them again with a bass note and the chord (oom-pah or oom-pah-pah).

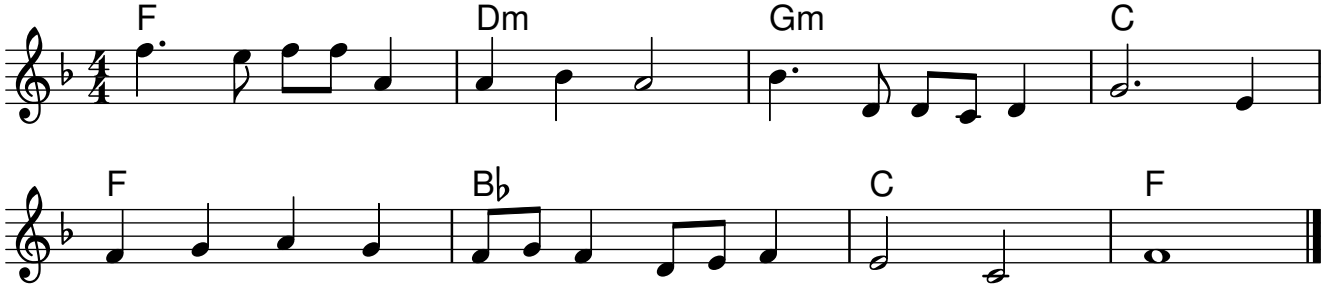
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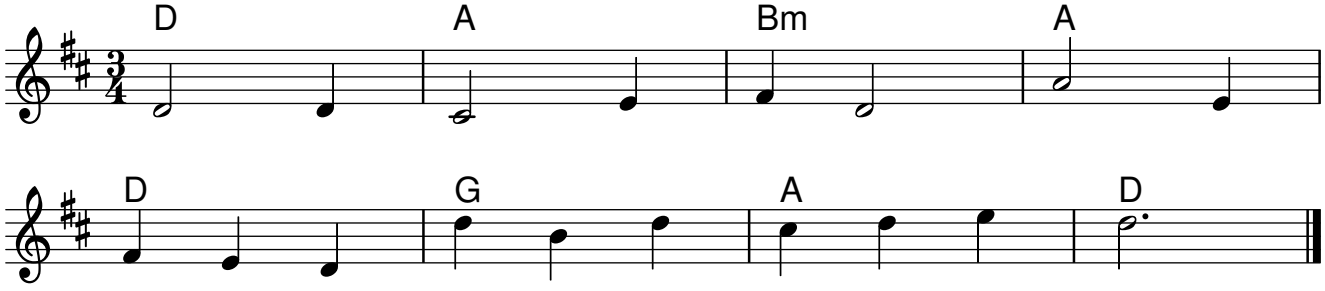
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☐ **8.3**



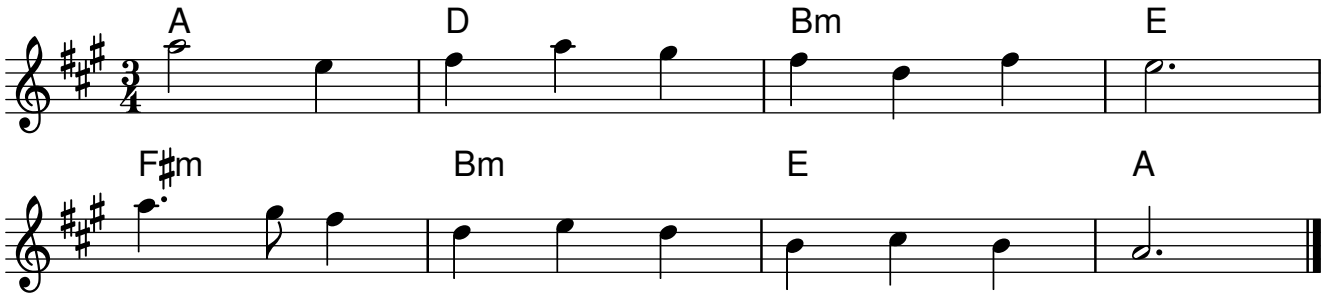
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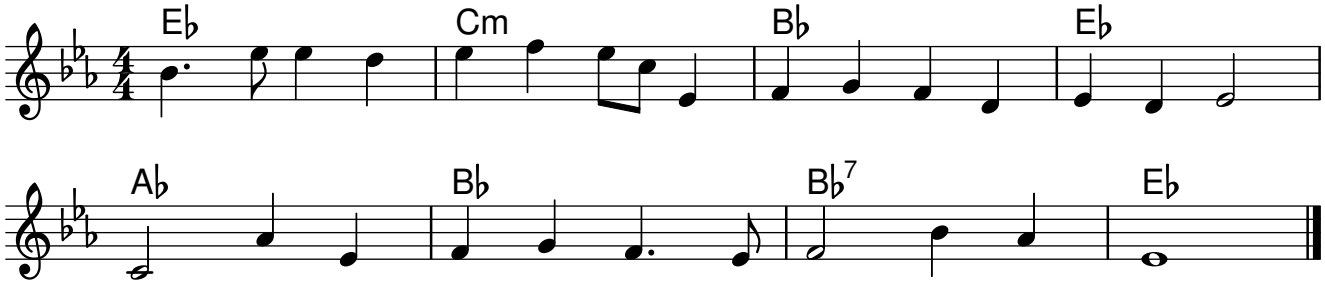
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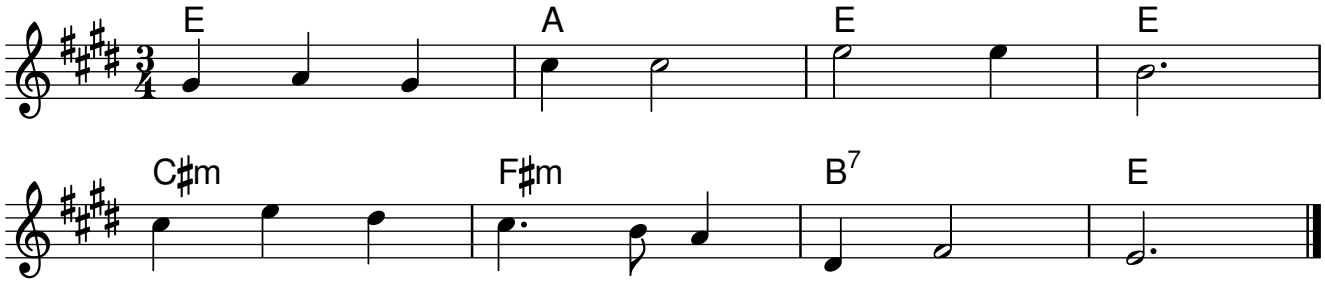
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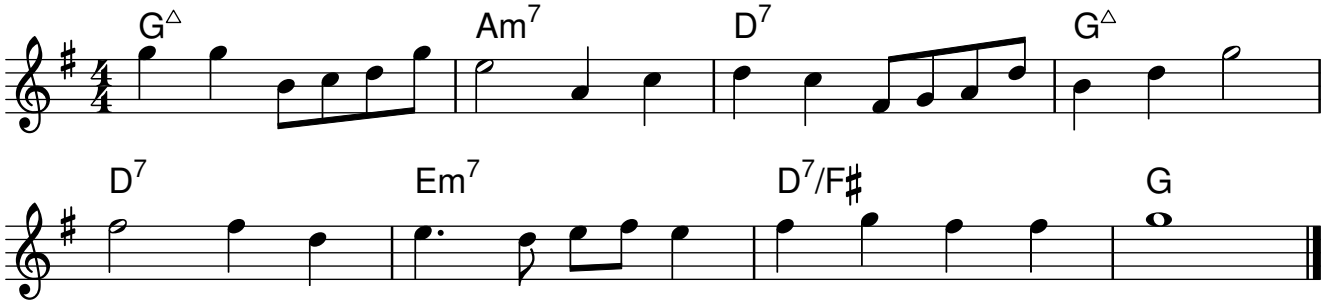
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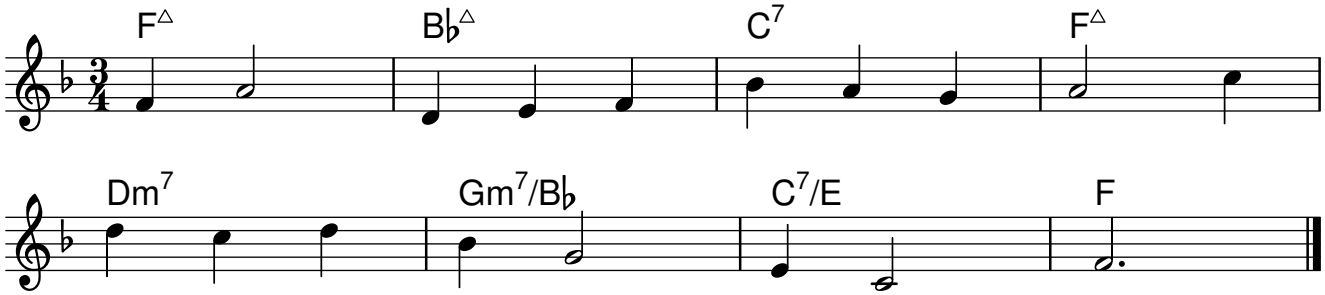
Part B: Lead sheets: sevenths and slash chords ♩ = 72

Lead sheets with seventh chords and slash chords. Choose an accompaniment pattern (block chords, oom-pah, broken chords) and keep it all through.

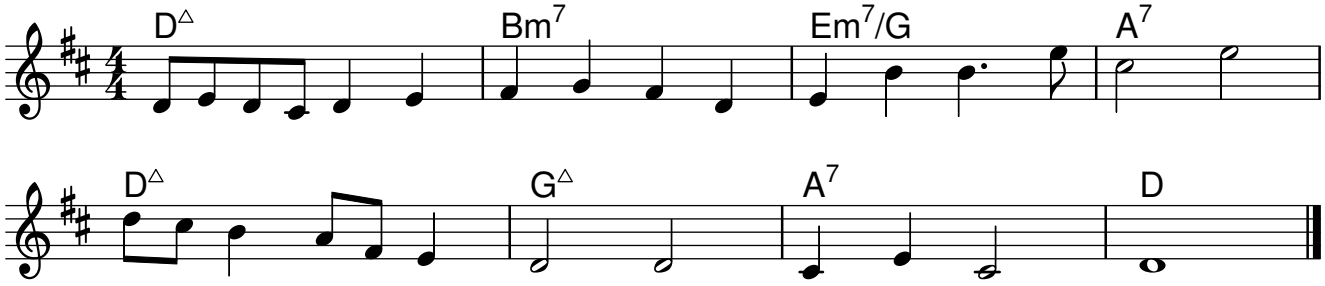
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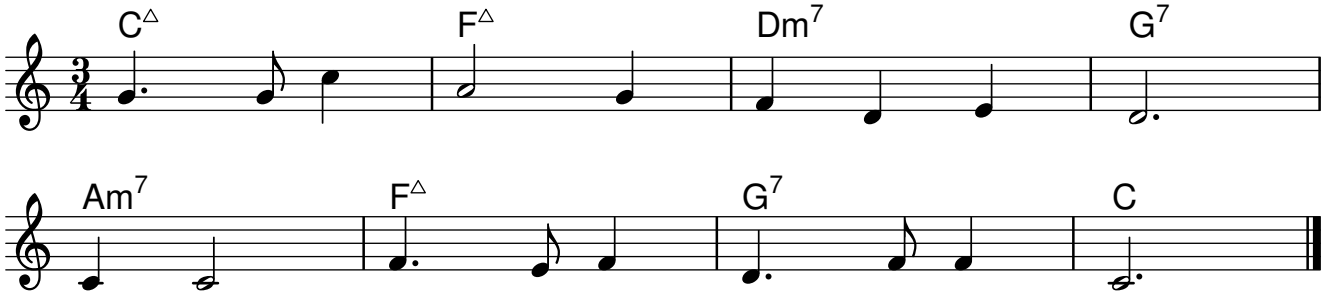
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☐ **8.11**



☐ **8.12**



☐ **8.13**



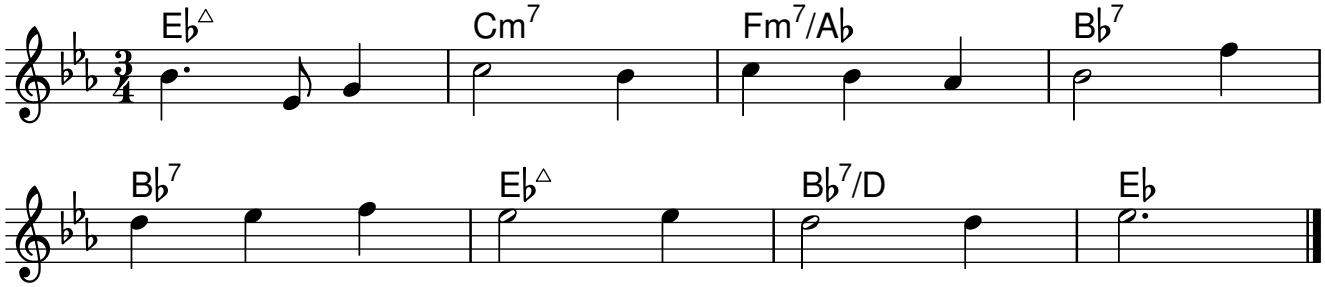
8.14



8.15



8.16



Part C: Review: one of each ♩ = 60

Review: one exercise of each kind from this volume: the middle voice changing hands, a hemiola, 7/8, secondary dominants, octaves, a song, a string quartet and a fugue exposition.

☐ **8.17**



☐ **8.18** ♩ = 96



☐ **8.19** ♪ = 160



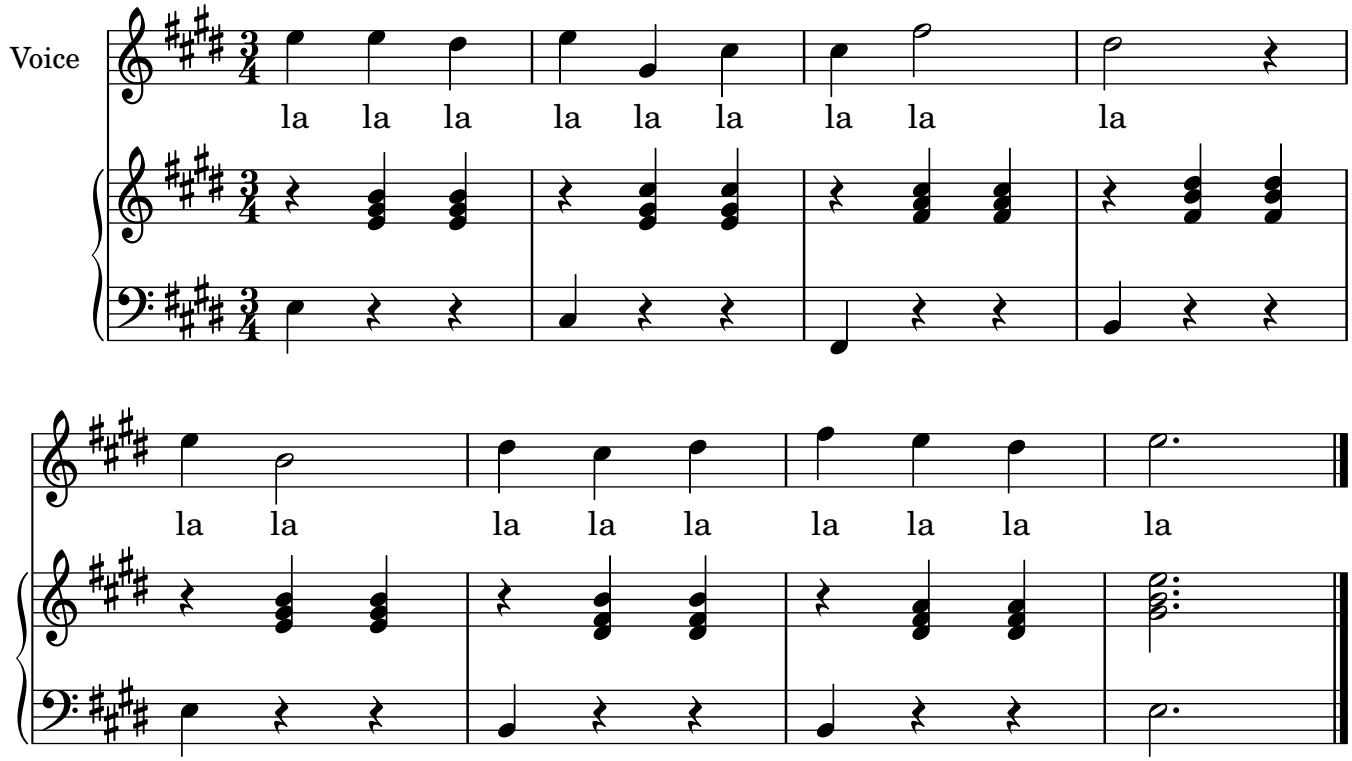
8.20 ♩ = 56



8.21 ♩ = 72



8.22 ♩ = 88



8.23



8.24 ♩ = 56



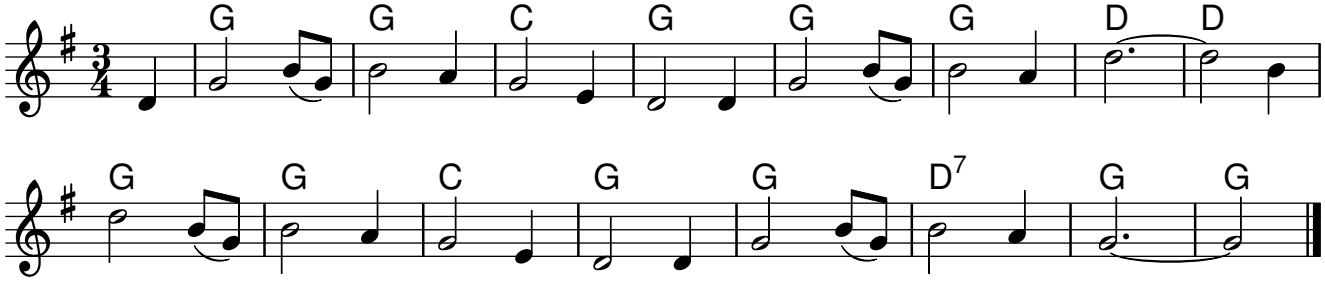
Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

Amazing Grace ♩ = 84

Traditional (the tune "New Britain"), a lead sheet

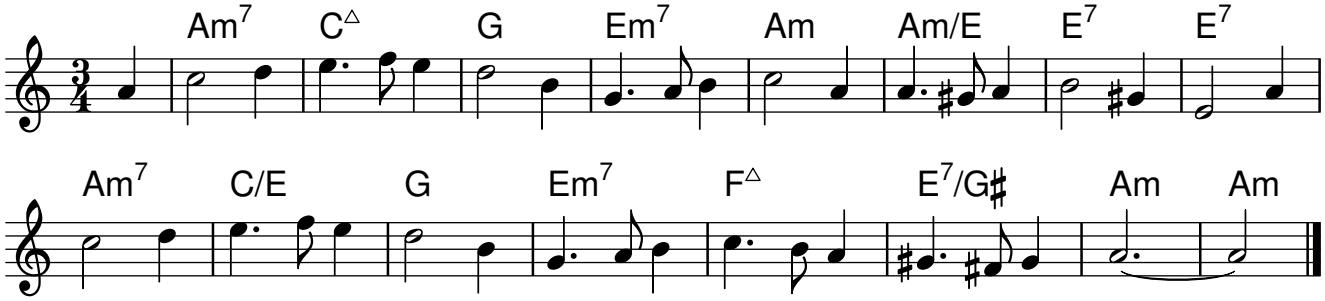
A lead sheet: the tune and the chord symbols only. Play the tune with the right hand and make the accompaniment with the left: first each chord in root position, held for the bar, then a bass note and two chords (oom-pah-pah). D7 in bar 14 leads home to G.



Greensleeves ♩ = 92

Traditional English tune (16th century), a lead sheet

A lead sheet with seventh chords and slash chords. Am7 is A C E G; Cmaj7 is C E G B; E7/G-sharp has G-sharp in the bass. Choose an accompaniment (block chords, or a bass note and two chords) and keep it steady; the G-sharps in the tune belong to the E7 chords.



Old Hundredth 𝅗𝅥 = 72

Genevan Psalter (1551), the hymn tune "Old Hundredth"

Transposing at sight: play the tune as printed (G major), then a tone lower in F major (one flat), then a tone higher in A major (three sharps). Read the shape of each line, not the note names. When you can, add a bass note under each half note with the left hand.



Waltz: Bethena ♩ = 96

Scott Joplin (1905), Bethena: A Concert Waltz - the first strain, with chord symbols

Joplin's waltz, with chord symbols added above it (they are not in Joplin's score): read the harmony of each bar as a symbol, then find it in the notes. A7/E is A7 with E in the bass; C6 adds A to C major. The right hand plays the tune over held lower notes. Joplin holds the bass octaves of bars 3, 8 and 11 (with the pedal); here they are quarter notes. Source: Mutopia Project no. 463 (public domain).



Clair de lune ♩. = 44

Claude Debussy (1890-1905), Suite bergamasque: Clair de lune - bars 1-8, with a closing chord

The last piece of the course. 9/8: three slow beats of three eighths. The music floats: tied notes hide the beat, and in bar 3 two duplets (two notes in the time of three) sound against the eighths. Both hands start in the treble clef; the left hand moves to the bass clef in bar 6. Five flats, and in bar 2 a B double-flat (the white key A). Debussy asks for "con sordina" (the soft pedal); use the sustain pedal lightly at each change of harmony. Source: Mutopia Project no. 1778 (public domain).



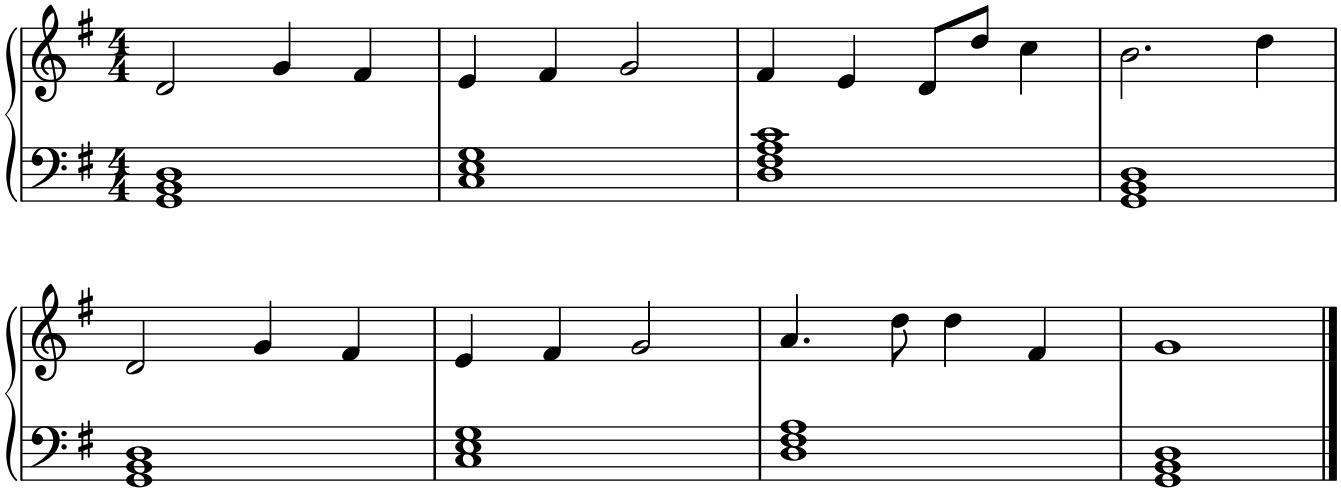
The end of the course

- Play two new exercises from each part at the speed shown, with no more than one stop each.
- Pass if you can play Amazing Grace and Greensleeves from their lead sheets with a steady left-hand accompaniment, and Old Hundredth in three keys.
- Pass if you can play the review exercises of Part C at sight, and Clair de lune after a few days.
- What next: read something new every day. Hymnals, the Bach chorales, Schubert's songs with a singer, Haydn quartets with friends, Mozart and Haydn sonatas, Chopin's mazurkas, folk-song books and lead sheets. You are a sight-reader now: keep the habit.

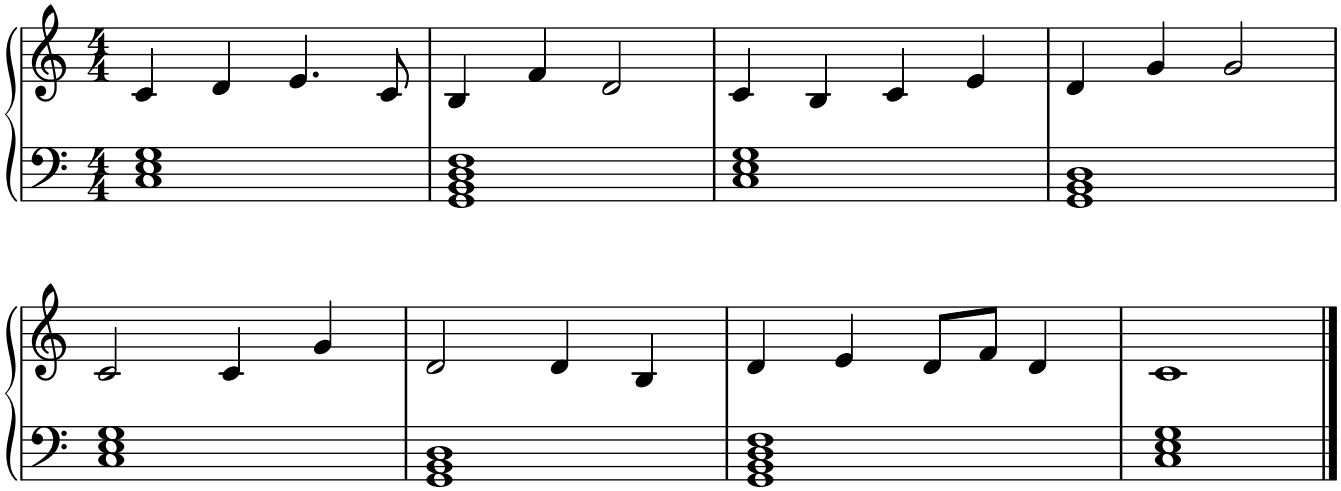
Answers

The transposing exercises, written out in their target keys. Play first; check yourself here afterwards.

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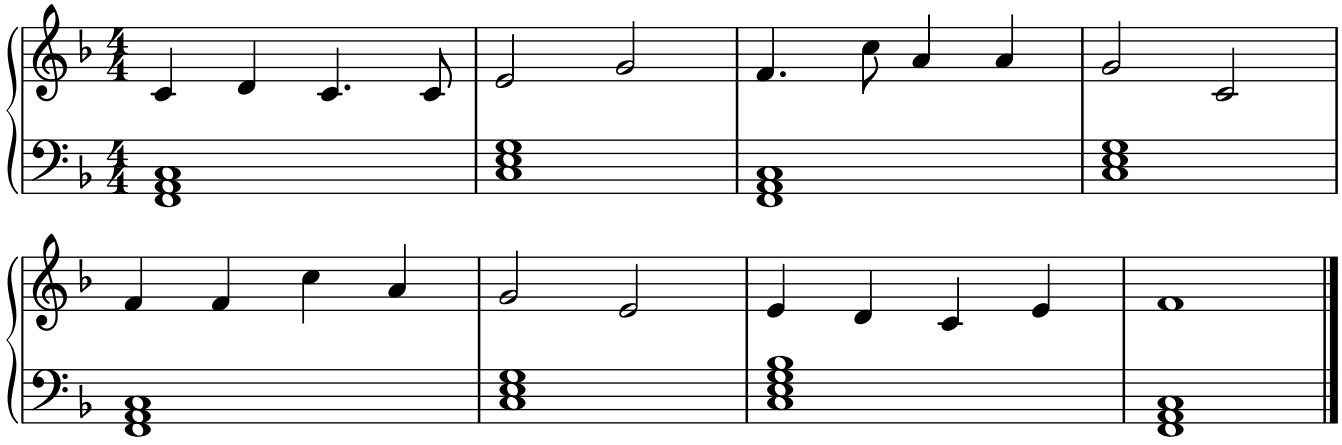
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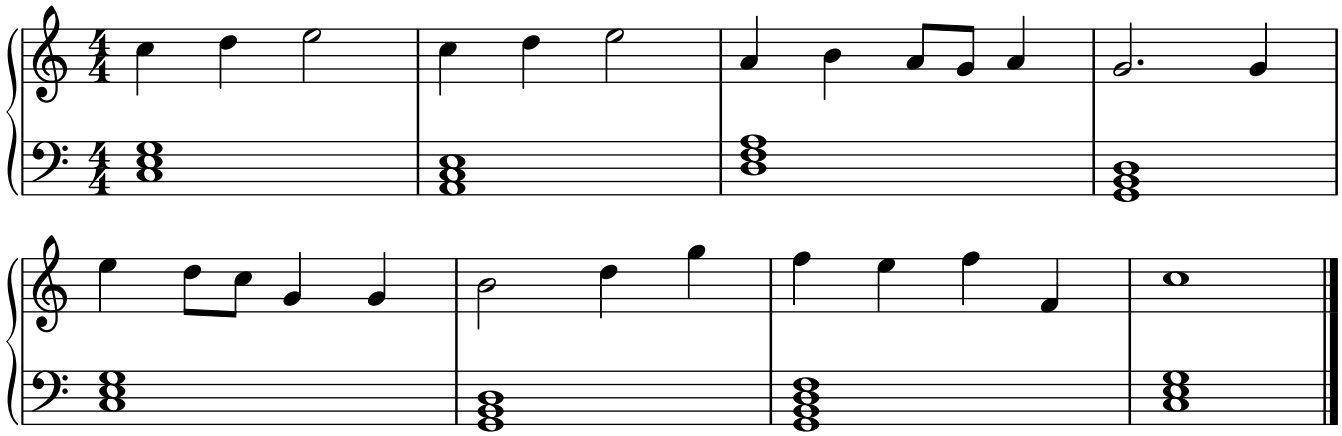
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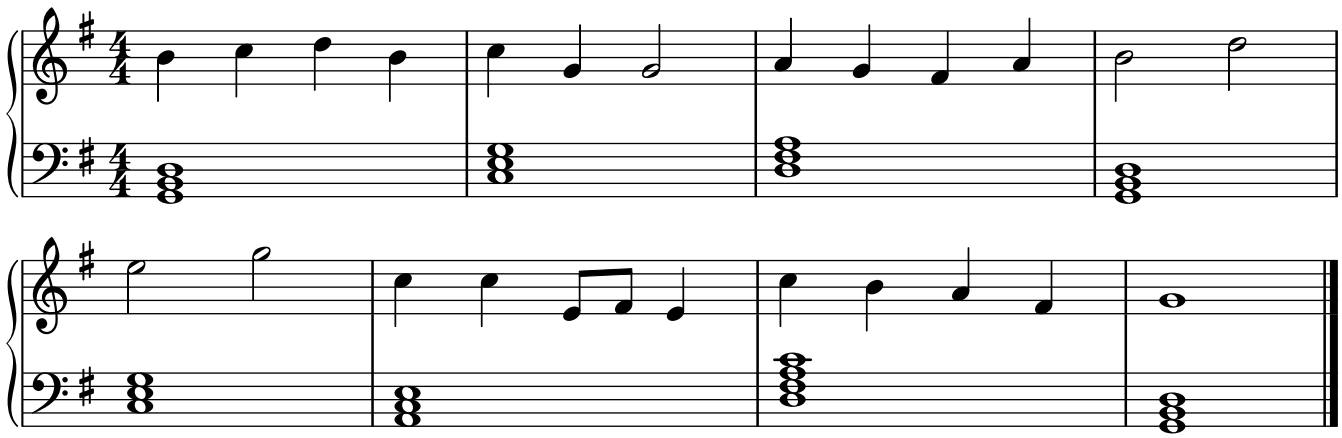
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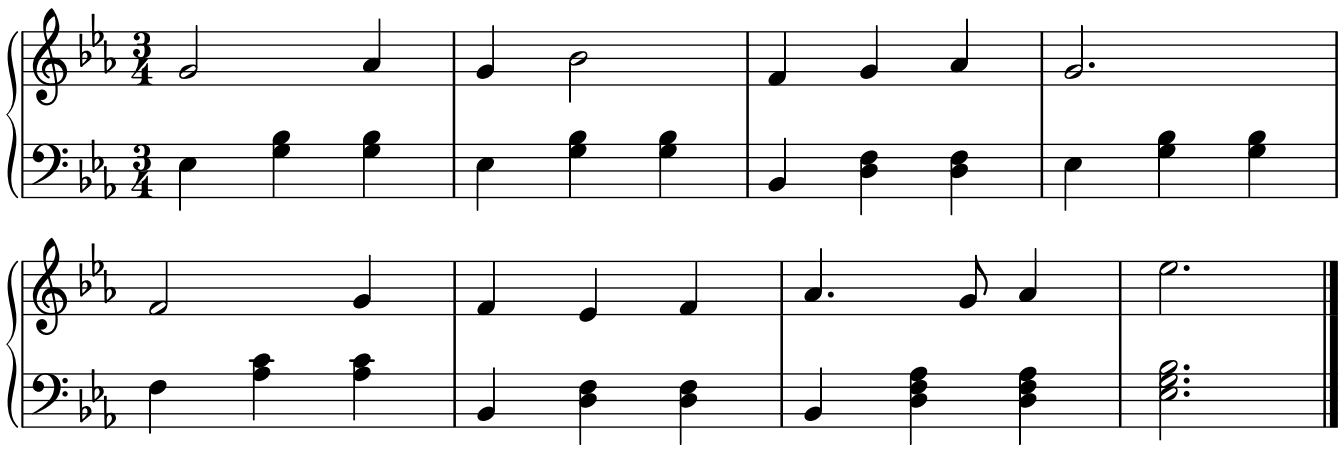
7.21



7.22



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